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Topological Data Analysis – Lecture 2

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AGQ Computing Course

6 March 2026

Recap of Persistent Homology (PH)



Topological Data Analysis (TDA) refers to statistical methods that rely on topological ideas to find structure in data

Persistent homology pipeline

1. Metric geometry: Given data $X = \{X_1, \dots, X_n\} \subset M$ in some metric space, construct a family of cell complexes $\{X_t \mid t \in \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}\}$
2. Algebraic topology: Compute the k -th homology vector spaces $H_k(X_t)$ across scales $t \in \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ and dimensions $k \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$
3. Representation theory: Decompose each family of vector spaces $\{H_k(X_t) \mid t \geq 0\}$ into irreducible summands yielding *barcodes*

The barcodes are finite multi-sets of real intervals $[p, q] \subset \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$

Recap: Filtered simplicial complexes



Main example. Finite subset of points $M = \{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n\} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$

Definition. Let (M, d) be a finite metric space. The **Vietoris-Rips filtration** is an “increasing family” of simplicial complexes $VR_\epsilon(M)$ indexed by the real numbers $\epsilon \geq 0$ defined as follows:

A subset $\{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_k\} \subset M$ forms a k -dimensional simplex in $VR_\epsilon(M)$ if and only if we have $d(x_i, x_j) \leq \epsilon$ for all i, j

Recap: Persistent homology groups



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With a filtered simplicial complex in place (either VR or Čech), we obtain a persistence module from the k -th homology, i.e.,

$$H_k(F_\bullet K) : H_k(F_0 K) \rightarrow H_k(F_1 K) \rightarrow \dots \rightarrow H_k(F_{n-1} K) \rightarrow H_k(F_n K)$$

we obtain **persistent homology groups** $\mathrm{PH}_k g_{i \rightarrow j}(F_\bullet K)$ for $i \leq j$

Recap: Persistent homology groups

With a filtered simplicial complex in place (either VR or Cech), we obtain a persistence module from the k -th homology, i.e.,

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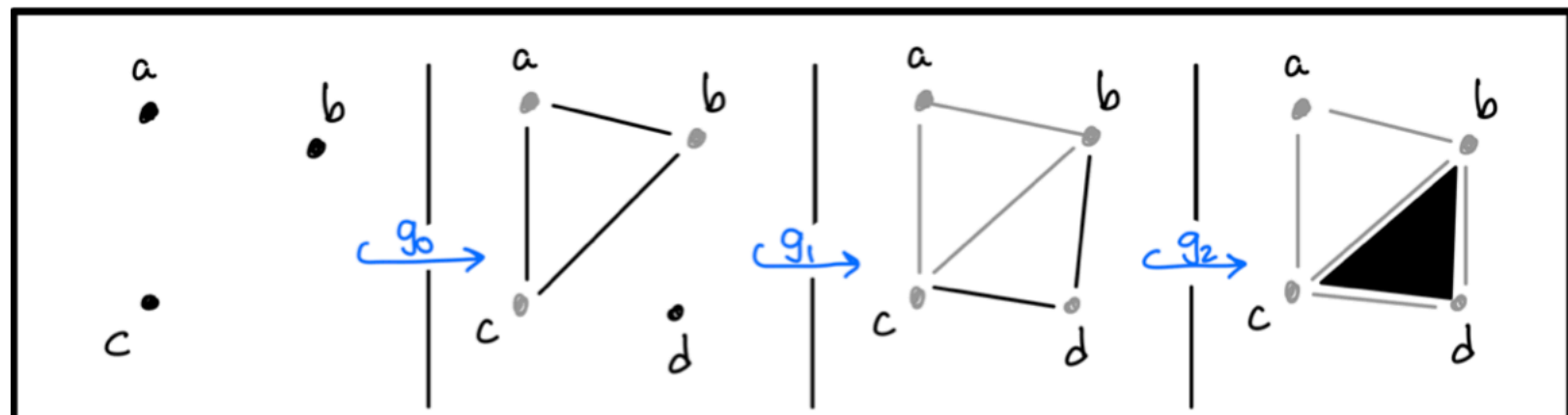
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Interpretation. The elements are homology classes in $H_k(F_i K)$ which continue to generate non-trivial homology classes in the larger simplicial complex $F_j K$. These are (equivalence classes of) k -cycles in $F_i K$ which do not become k -boundaries in $F_j K$

Compare

$$\{a, b, c\} \in \text{PH}_1 g_{1 \rightarrow 3}(F_\bullet K)$$

$$\{b, c, d\} \in \text{PH}_1 g_{2 \rightarrow 3}(F_\bullet K)$$



Recap: Persistent homology groups



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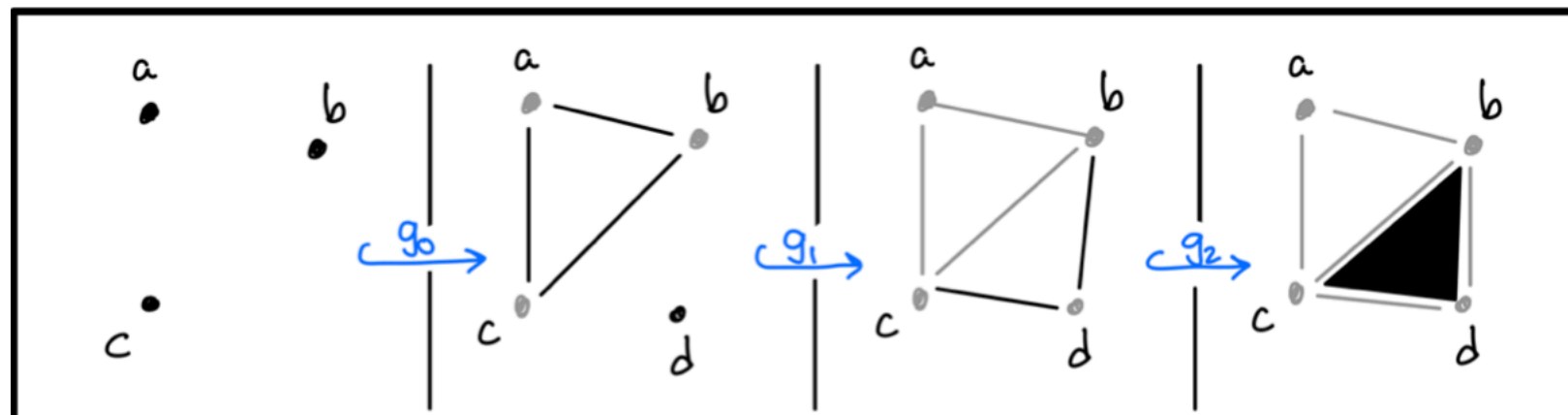
In fact:
$$\text{PH}_k g_{i \rightarrow j}(F_\bullet K) = \frac{H_k g_{i \rightarrow j}(\ker \partial_k^i)}{H_k g_{i \rightarrow j}(\ker \partial_k^i) \cap \text{im}(\partial_{k+1}^j)}$$

Note that $\text{PH}_k g_{i \rightarrow i}(F_\bullet K) = H_k(F_i K)$

Compare

$$\{a, b, c\} \in \text{PH}_1 g_{1 \rightarrow 3}(F_\bullet K)$$

$$\{b, c, d\} \in \text{PH}_1 g_{2 \rightarrow 3}(F_\bullet K)$$



Recap: Barcode theorem



finite type,

Theorem. For any $\mathbb{N}$ -indexed persistence module $(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ over $\mathbb{F}$ there exists a set $\text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ of integer pairs $0 \leq i \leq j \leq \infty$ and a function $\mu: \text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet) \rightarrow \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ with the following property: There is a direct sum decomposition

$$(V_\bullet, a_\bullet) \simeq \bigoplus_{[i,j]} (I_\bullet^{i,j}, c_\bullet^{i,j})^{\mu(i,j)}$$

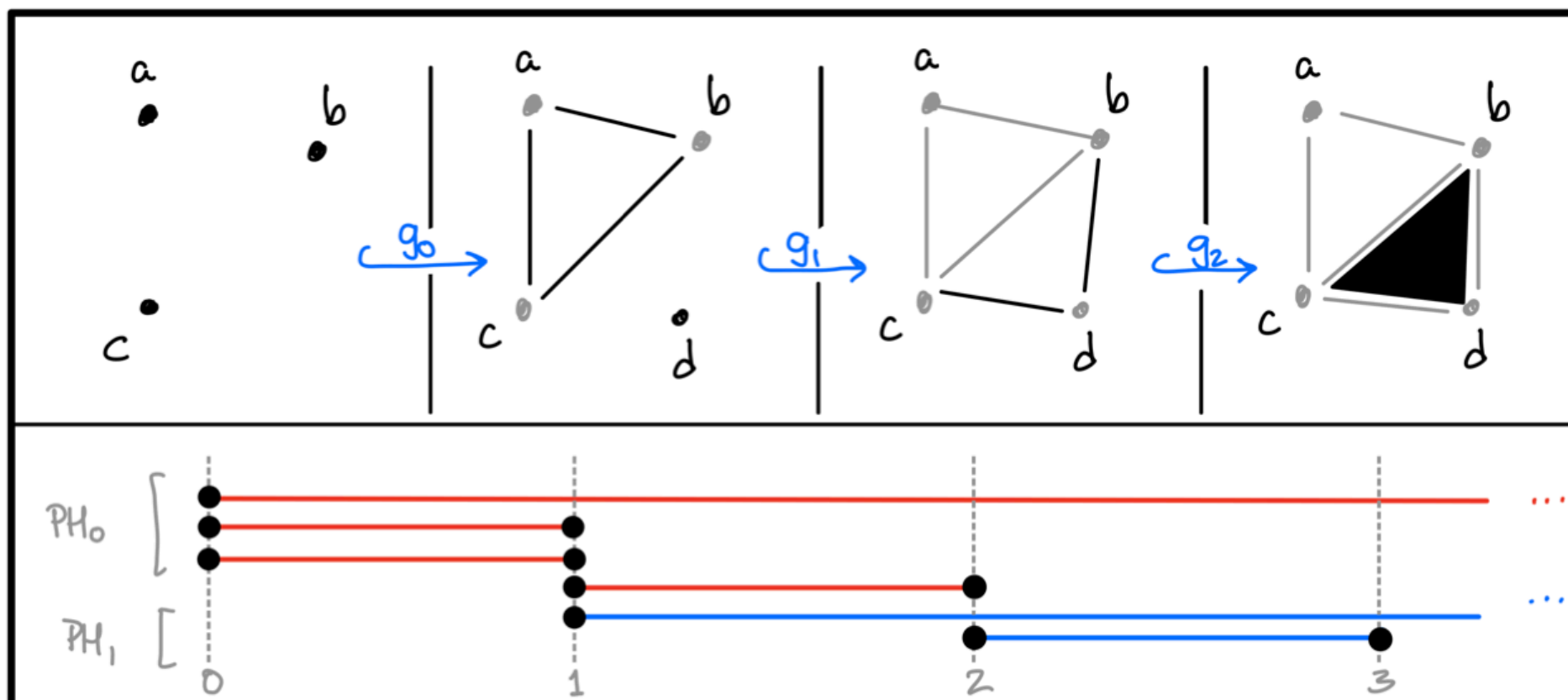
which is unique up to isomorphism of persistence modules.

Recap: Barcode theorem



Definition. For any $\mathbb{N}$ -indexed persistence module $(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ over $\mathbb{F}$ of finite type, the collection $\text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ of intervals $[i, j]$ and their multiplicities $\mu(i, j) \geq 1$ is called the **barcode** of $(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$

Example.



Structure of the lectures



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Lecture 1 (last week): Computing persistent homology

- Simplicial complexes and simplicial homology
- Vietoris-Rips complex and computation of PH
- Structure result: The barcode theorem

Tutorial: Pen-and-paper questions + notebook to compute PH

Lecture 2 (today): Leveraging persistent homology

- Stability of barcodes and persistence diagrams
- Vectorisation of persistence diagrams
- Applications of PH/TDA in machine learning

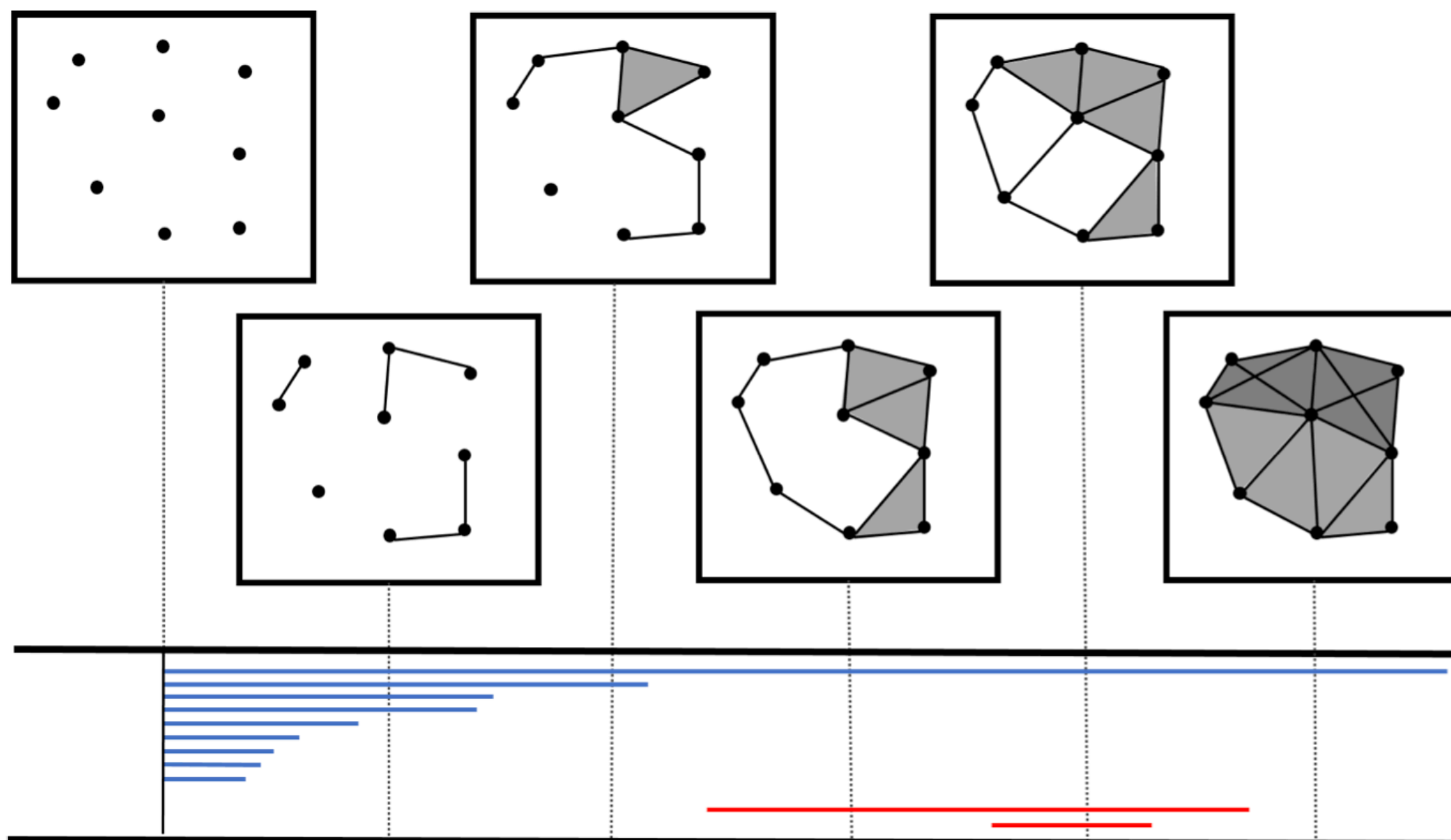
Tutorial: Data sets to sharpen your skills!

Barcode theorem (revisited)



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Remark. Our persistence modules are $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ -indexed



Barcode theorem (revisited)



Remark. Our persistence modules are $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ -indexed

Definition. An $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ -indexed **persistence module** over $\mathbb{F}$ is a pair $(V_{\bullet}, a_{\bullet})$ of vector spaces $\{V_t\}$ and linear maps $\{a_{s \leq t} : V_s \rightarrow V_t\}$ s.t.

1. Identity: $a_{t \leq t}$ is the identity on V_t
2. Composition: $a_{s \leq t} \circ a_{r \leq s} = a_{r \leq t}$ for all $0 \leq r \leq s \leq t$

Note. A persistence module is a functor $(\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}, \leq) \rightarrow \mathbf{Vect}_{\mathbb{F}}$

Barcode theorem (revisited)

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Definition. A persistence module $(V_{\bullet}, a_{\bullet})$ is called **tame** if

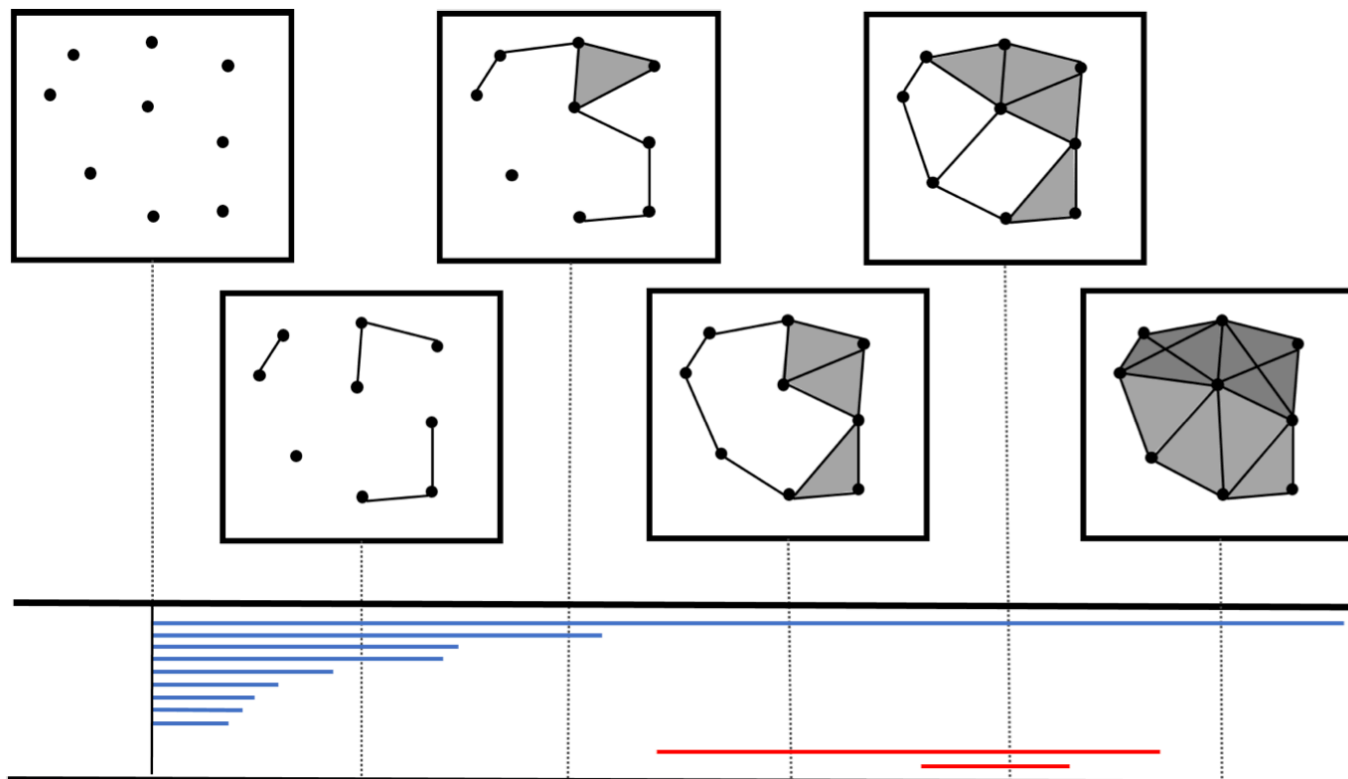
1. The V_t are finite-dimensional
2. There are only finitely many $t \geq 0$ s.t. $a_{t-\epsilon, t+\epsilon} : V_{t-\epsilon} \rightarrow V_{t+\epsilon}$ fails to be an isomorphism for arbitrarily small $\epsilon > 0$

Barcode theorem (revisited)

Theorem. For every tame persistence module $(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ over $\mathbb{F}$ there exists a set $\text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ of intervals $[s, t] \subset \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ and a function $\mu: \text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet) \rightarrow \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ with a $\oplus$ -decomposition

$$(V_\bullet, a_\bullet) \simeq \bigoplus_{[s,t]} (I_\bullet^{s,t}, c_\bullet^{s,t})^{\mu(s,t)}$$

which is unique up to isomorphism of persistence modules.



Stability theorem



By the Barcode theorem, we have an identification of

- Tame persistence modules $(V_{\bullet}, a_{\bullet})$ (up to isomorphism)
- Multi-sets of intervals $[s, t] \subset \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0} \cup \{\infty\}$

so an algebraic object and combinatorial data

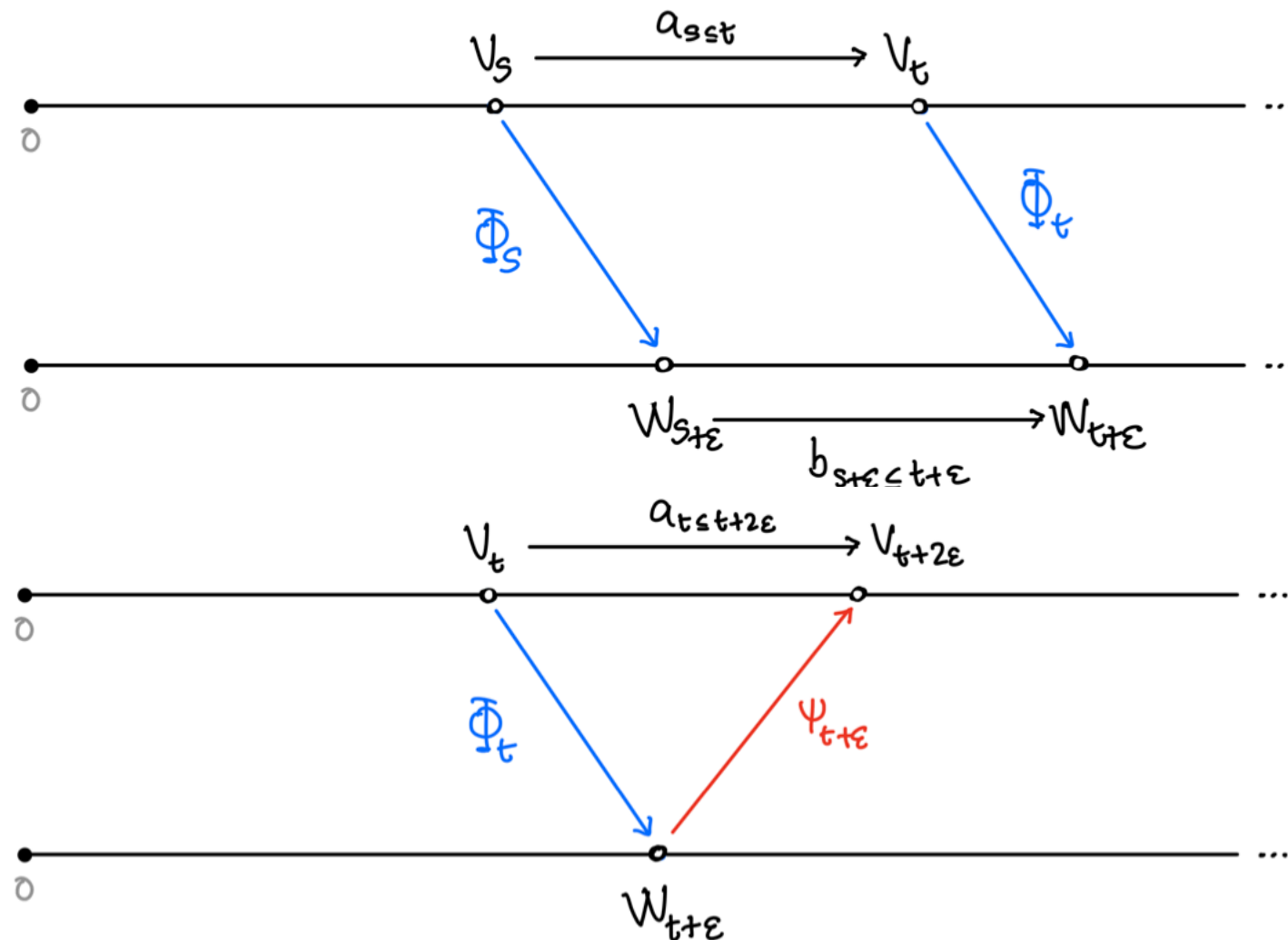
There are natural metrics on both sides:

- *Interleaving distance*, on the set of persistence modules
- *Bottleneck distance*, on the set of barcodes

Stability theorem

The assignment $(V_{\bullet}, a_{\bullet}) \mapsto \text{Bar}(V_{\bullet}, a_{\bullet})$ is an isometry

Stability theorem: Interleaving



Definition. The *interleaving distance* between persistence modules is the infimum over all $\epsilon \geq 0$ for which there is an ϵ -*interleaving* between them. If no such interleaving exists, it is infinite

Note. 0-interleavings are isomorphisms of persistence modules

Stability theorem: Bottleneck

Definition. An ϵ -**matching** between multi-sets of intervals is a bijection $\rho: B_0 \rightarrow B'_0$ of multi-subsets $B_0 \subset B, B'_0 \subset B'$ s.t.

1. Every $[s, t] \in (B \setminus B_0) \cup (B' \setminus B'_0)$ has length $t - s \leq 2\epsilon$
2. If $\rho[s, t] = [s', t']$ then we have $|s - s'|, |t - t'| \leq \epsilon$

Idea: All “long” intervals are paired up with intervals “close by”



Definition. The **bottleneck distance** between multi-sets of intervals is the infimum over all $\epsilon \geq 0$ for which there is an ϵ -matching between them.

Application of the Stability theorem



Proposition. Let P and Q be two finite point-sets in $\mathbb{R}^n$ which are close in the following sense. There is some $\epsilon > 0$ for which

1. There is a point of Q within distance ϵ of any point in P ,
2. There is a point of P within distance ϵ of any point in Q .

Then for $k \geq 0$, the k -th persistence homology modules of the Vietoris-Rips filtrations $VR_{\bullet}(P)$ and $VR_{\bullet}(Q)$ are 2ϵ -interleaved

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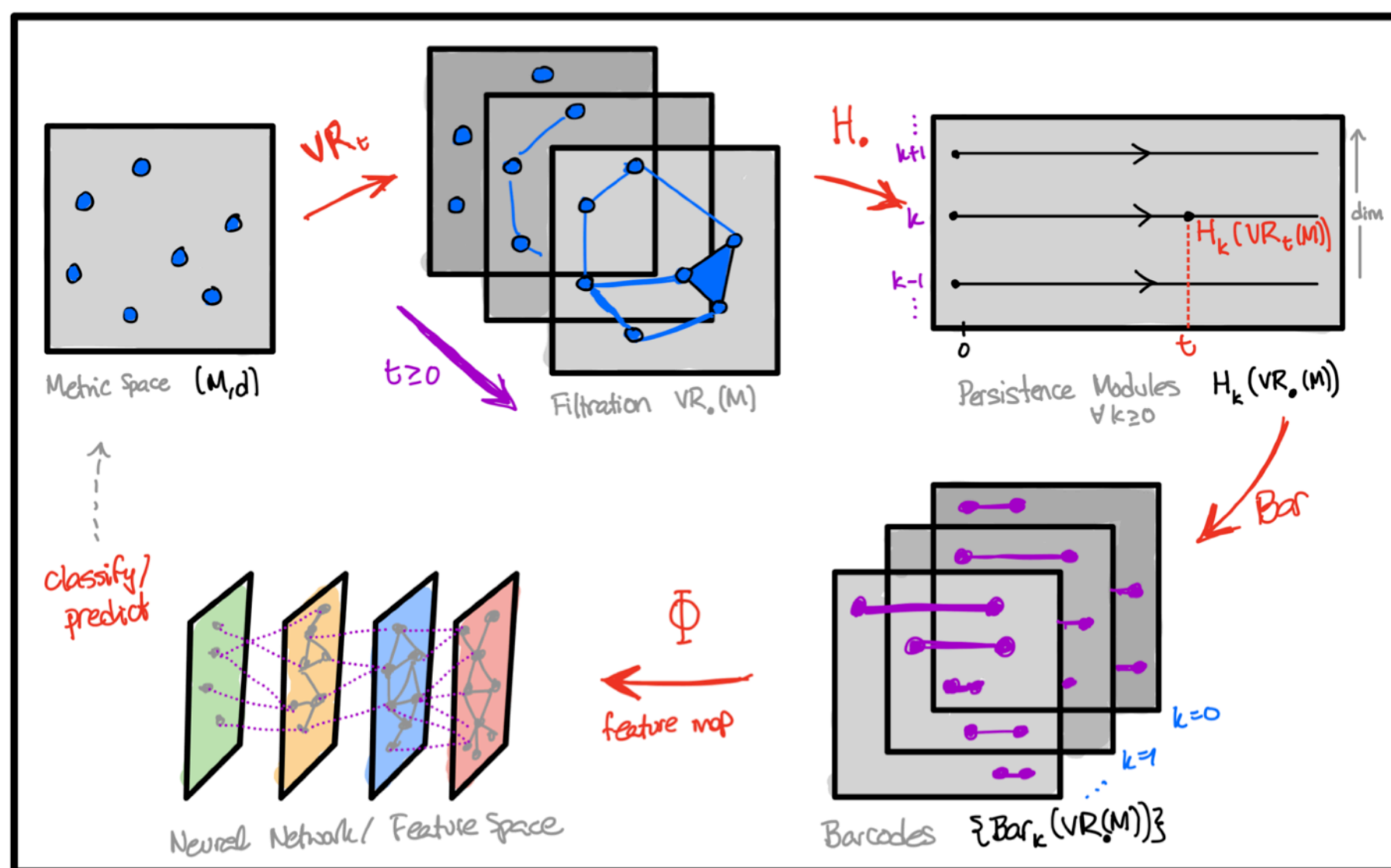
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Then for $k \geq 0$, the k -th persistence homology modules of the Vietoris-Rips filtrations $VR_{\bullet}(P)$ and $VR_{\bullet}(Q)$ are 2ϵ -interleaved

Corollary. For any finite point-sets $P, Q \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ as above, the k -th order PH barcodes from the VR complex have the same number of “sufficiently long” bars, i.e., those with length $\geq 4\epsilon$.

Question: Points on a circle with(out) outlier point in the middle?

Persistent homology in Machine Learning



Leveraging PH in ML



Almost completed the *topological data analysis pipeline*: what remains is preparing the multi-set of barcodes for a training task

For unstructured data without an inner product, use the *kernel trick*, i.e., embed data into a Hilbert space of functions

$$\phi: \mathcal{B} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}_{\mathcal{B}} \subset \{f: \mathcal{B} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}\}$$

via the feature map. By Moore-Aronszajn (1950), equivalent to the choice of a symmetric positive definition kernel on $\mathcal{B}$

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Despite nice isometry between persistent modules and barcodes, these metric spaces do not have favourable properties

Theorem (Bubenik-Wagner, 2020). The metric space of barcodes with the bottleneck distance does not admit an isometric (or even coarse) embedding into a Hilbert space.

Leveraging PH in ML



Coarse embeddings are a more general notion of embedding:

1. Not necessarily continuous,
2. Distances need to be distorted in a uniform way, which is allowed to be non-linear.

Conclusion. Any **vectorisation** of the metric space of persistence modules (or barcodes), i.e., any possible feature map into a Hilbert space, necessarily distorts the original metric

... thus the method of vectorisation is a choice, analogous to setting the value of hyper-parameters in ML

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Note. It is possible to work with distance between PMs or barcodes only, but this gets computationally costly!

Overview of vectorisations

Based on *A Survey of Vectorisation Methods in TDA (2023)*

They distinguish 5 (non-disjoint) classes of vectorisations

1. *Statistical*: A vector of basic statistical quantities
2. *Algebraic*: Generated from polynomials
3. *Curve*: Maps into a vector space of the form $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow H$
4. *Functional*: Similar, but $\mathbb{R} \neq X \rightarrow H$
5. *Ensemble*: Generated from collections of training barcodes

Compare performance in three classification tasks

Provide a web (+ downloadable) app to play with!

Curve vectorisation

Definition. Given the barcode $B = \text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ of a tame PM with multiplicity $\mu: B \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ and an interval $[p, q]$, we call p the *birth*, q the *death*, and the length $q - p$ the *lifespan* of the bar, respectively.

Definition. The **Betti curve** of $\mu: B \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ is $\beta_\mu: \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$

$$\beta_\mu(t) = \sum_{[p, q] \in B} \mathbb{1}_{p \leq t \leq q} \cdot \mu_{p, q}$$

counting the number of intervals (+ multiplicity) which contain t .

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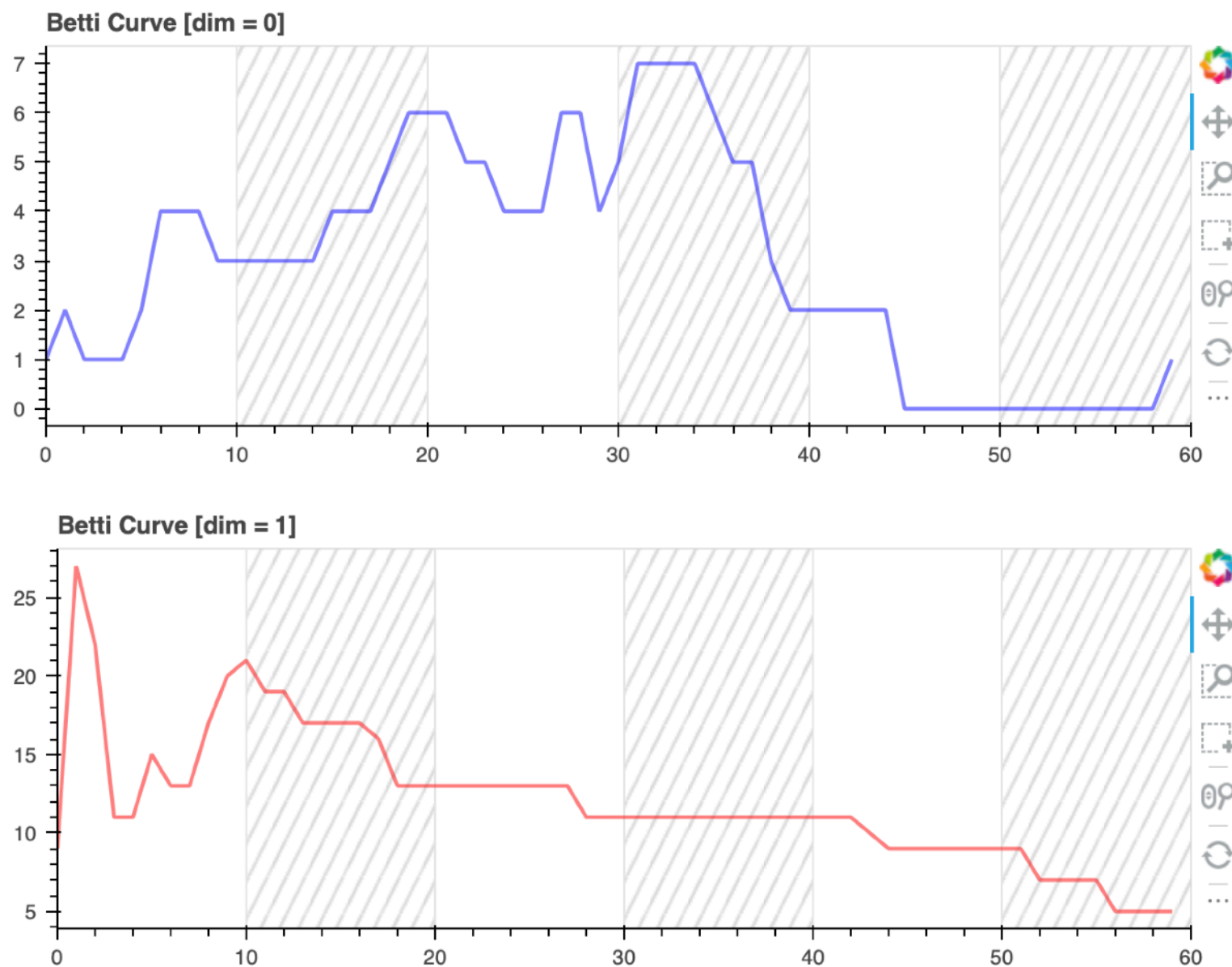
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Curve vectorisation: Betti

In practice, we choose, e.g., 100 equally spaced values of the parameter t , and record the function as an object in $\mathbb{R}^{100}$.

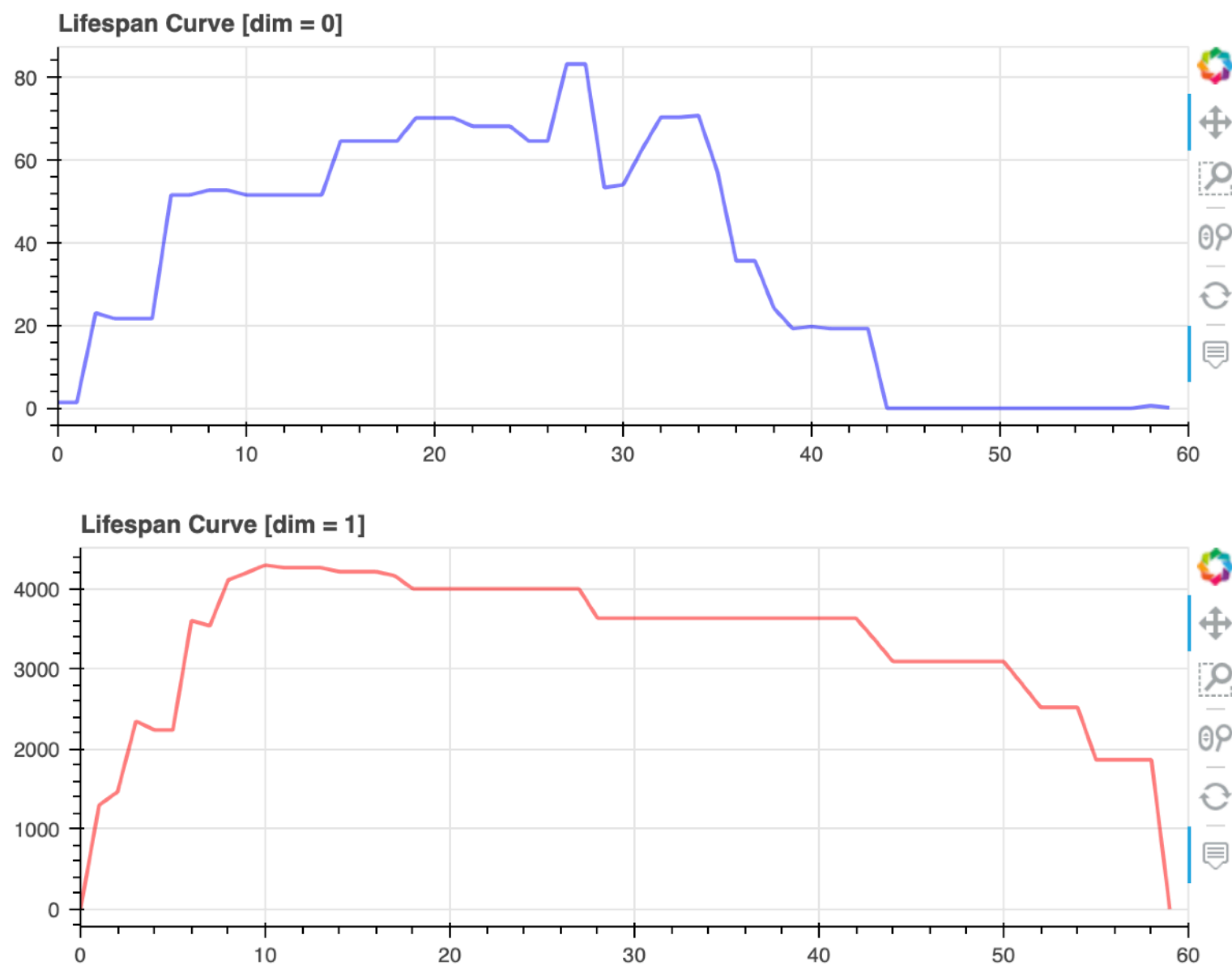


Curve vectorisation: Lifespan



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Curve vectorisation: Downside

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$$L_\mu(t) = \sum_{[p,q] \in B} \mathbb{1}_{p \leq t \leq q} \cdot \mu_{p,q} \cdot (q - p)$$

Downside: These notions are not “stable”. By adding lots of very small intervals, we can make the curves very different, yet make sure they have a small bottleneck distance

Curve vectorisation: Landscapes

Persistent landscapes offer a stabilisation, in which we replace the condition $t \in [p, q] \in B$ with the largest $s \geq 0$ such that

$$[t - s, t + s] \in [p, q] \in B$$

Definition. The **persistence landscape** of $\mu: B \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ is a sequence of curves $\Lambda_i^\mu: \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0} \rightarrow [-\infty, \infty]$ for $i \in \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ with image

$$\Lambda_i^\mu(t) = \sup \left\{ s \geq 0 \mid \sum_{[p,q] \in B} \mathbb{1}_{[t-s, t+s] \subset [p,q]} \cdot \mu_{p,q} \geq i \right\}$$

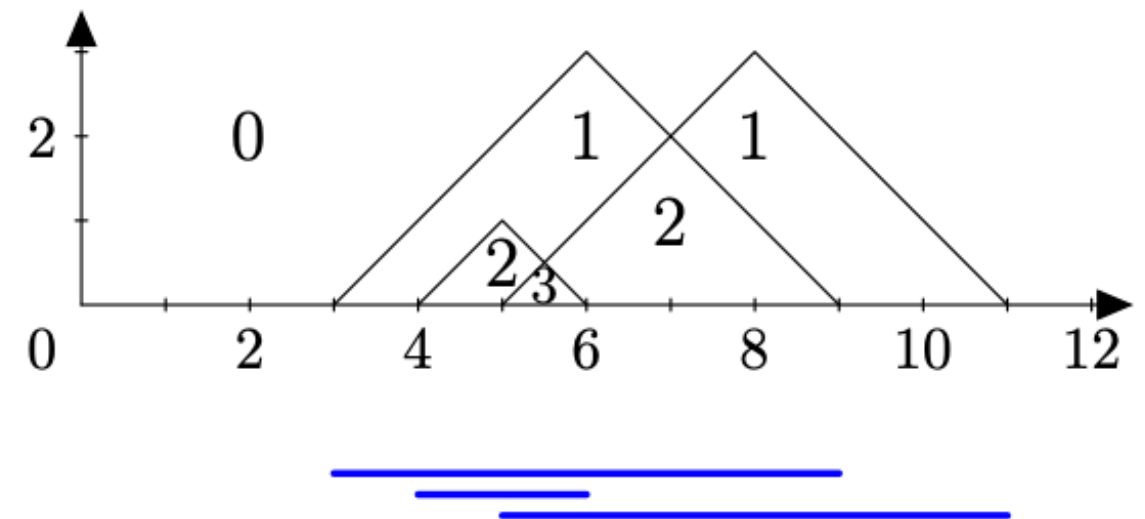
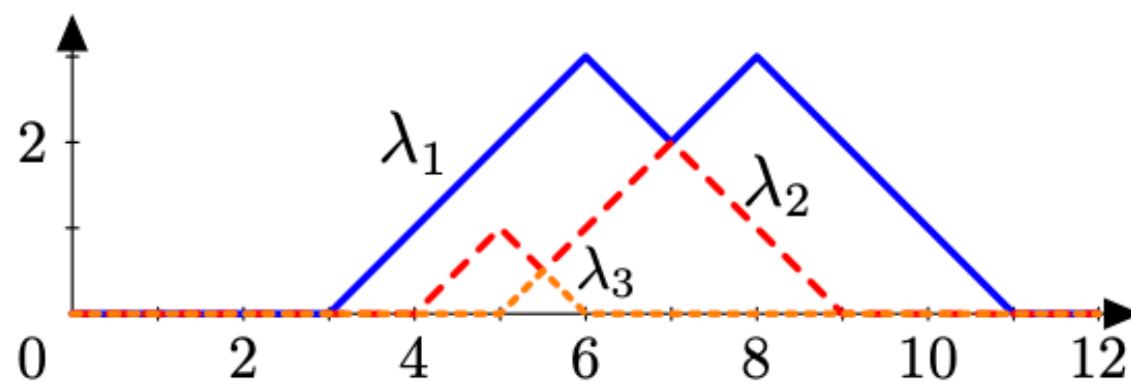
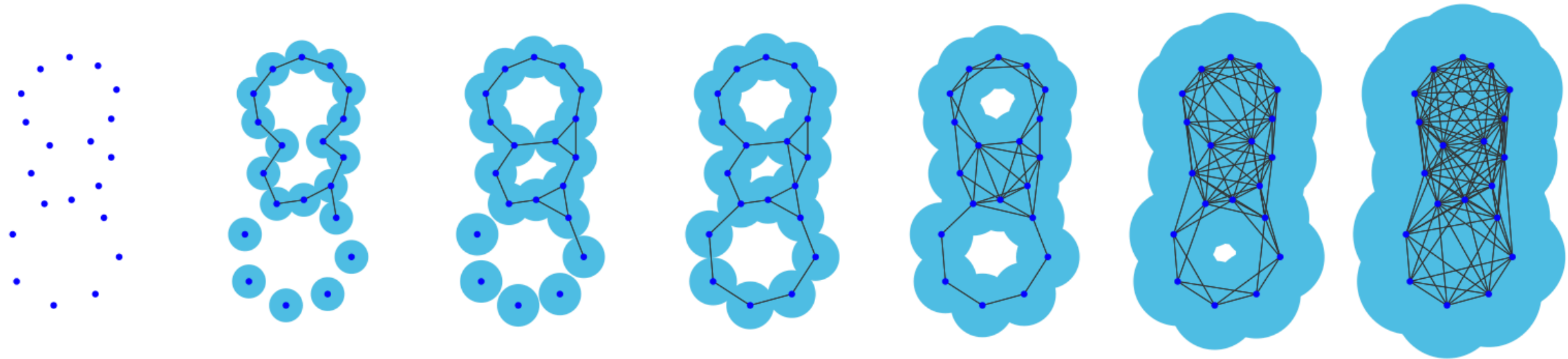
Remarks.

1. The supremum over the empty set is zero
2. Since our barcode B is finite, the functions are zero for $i \gg 0$

Curve vectorisation: Landscapes



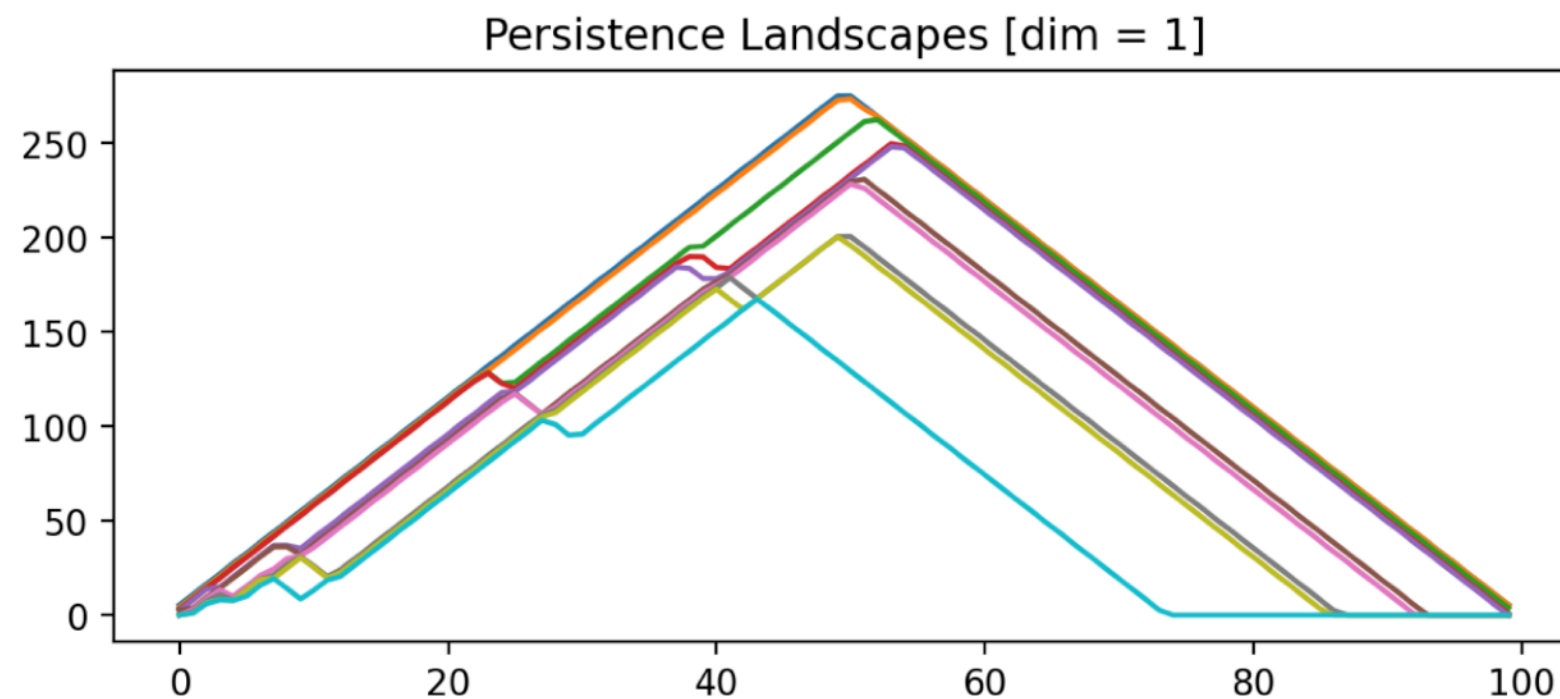
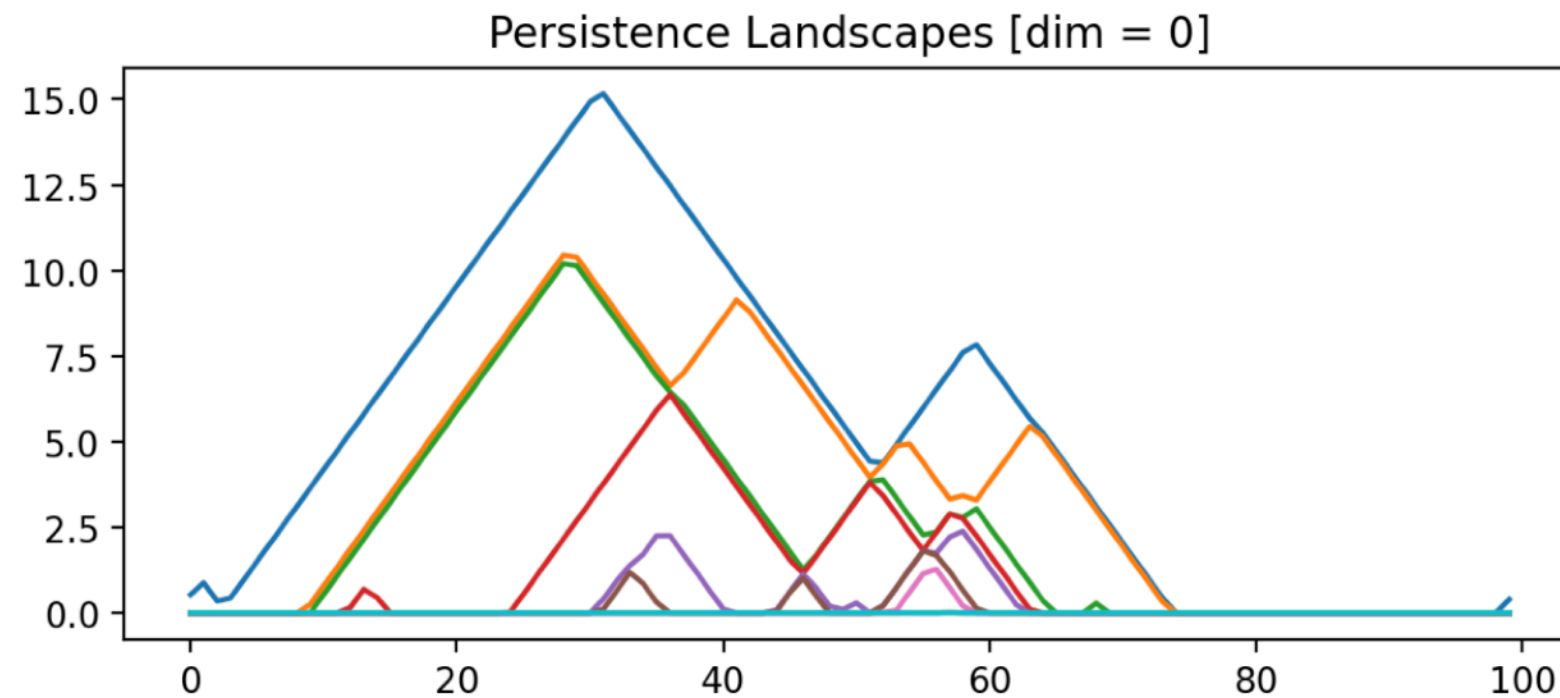
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Curve vectorisation: Landscapes



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Statistics on Persistence Landscapes



Via the vector space structure, we can take means of landscapes

Suppose we sample n point clouds, each yielding $\mu_j : B_j \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$

We obtain a *mean persistence landscape* via

$$\overline{\Lambda}_i(t) = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{j=1}^n \Lambda_i^{\mu_j}(t)$$

Statistics on Persistence Landscapes



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We obtain a *mean persistence landscape* via

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While this need not correspond to a meaningful landscape, using some probability theory on Banach spaces and obtain:

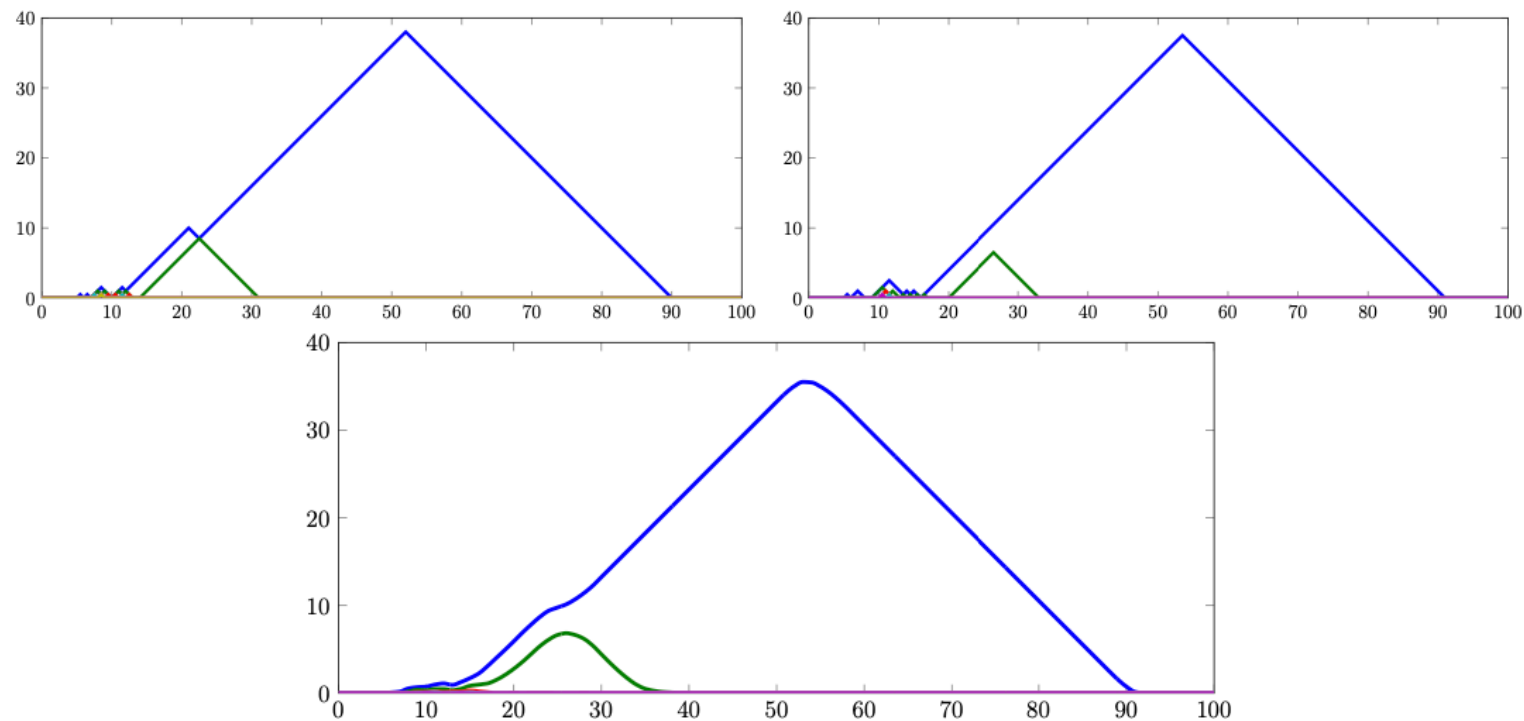
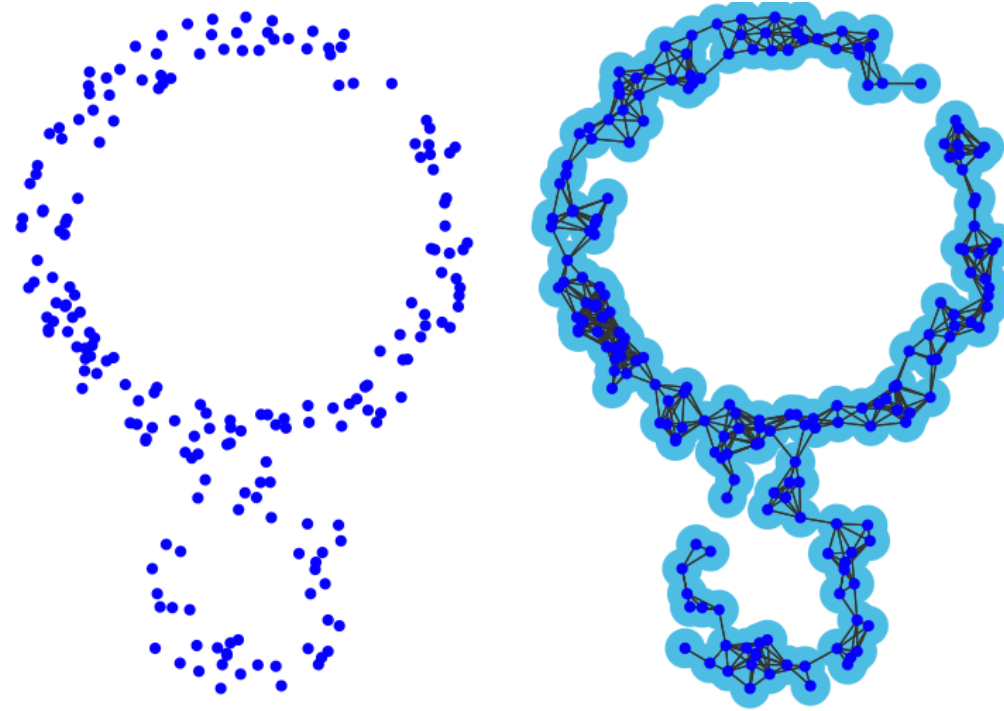
1. Strong LLN: $\bar{\Lambda}_i \rightarrow \mathbb{E}[\Lambda_i]$ almost surely
2. CLT: $\sqrt{n}(\bar{\Lambda}_i - \mathbb{E}[\Lambda_i])$ converges weakly to a Gaussian

By applying a functionals to PL's we obtain a regular (real-valued) random variable + CLT + hypothesis testing!

Statistics on Persistence Landscapes



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Use in ML

After selecting an appropriate vectorisation of our barcodes, we can next incorporate our newly defined *topological features* in a loss function of interest for a given machine learning task

Vectorization Method	Score	Param.	Estimator
Persistence Statistics	0.947	t_5	RF, n=100
Entropy Summary	0.723	$t_6, 200$	RF, n=300
Algebraic Functions	0.909	t_5	RF, n=500
Tropical Coordinates	0.844	$t_6, 50$	SVM, lin. kernel, C_5
Complex Polynomial	0.889	$t_6, 20, S$	SVM, lin. kernel, C_6
Betti Curve	0.728	$t_5, 200$	RF, n=100
Lifespan Curve	0.878	$t_7, 200$	SVM, lin. kernel, C_7
Persistence Landscape	0.889	$t_6, 50, 10$	SVM, rbf kernel, C_1, γ_1
Persistence Silhouette	0.867	$t_6, 200, 2$	SVM, rbf kernel, C_2, γ_2
Persistence Image	0.916	$t_5, 1, 10$	RF, n=100
Template Function	0.944	$t_5, 14, 0.7$	SVM, rbf kernel, C_3, γ_3
Adaptive Template Sys.	0.889	$t_5, \text{GMM}, 15$	SVM, lin. kernel, C_8
ATOL	0.933	$t_8, 16$	SVM, rbf kernel, C_4, γ_4

TABLE 3

Best performance of each method on **SHREC14**. The parameters are $C_1 = 835.6257$, $\gamma_1 = 0.0002$, $C_2 = 212.6281$, $\gamma_2 = 0.0031$, $C_3 = 879.1425$, $\gamma_3 = 0.0010$, $C_4 = 936.5391$, $\gamma_4 = 0.0187$, $C_5 = 141.3869$, $C_6 = 625.0300$, $C_7 = 998.1848$, $C_8 = 274.500$.

Task: Classification (15 classes), 70/30 training/testing, Score = accuracy

Use in ML



After selecting an appropriate vectorisation of our barcodes, we can next incorporate our newly defined *topological features* in a loss function of interest for a given machine learning task

Approach. Add a topological term to the loss function

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathcal{L}_0 + \lambda \mathcal{L}_{\text{topo}}$$

with a parameter to tune the relative contribution

Training. Differentiability a.e. of the persistence map, and thus for persistence based functions that are locally Lipschitz (e.g., PL) — required for back-propagation and stochastic gradient descent



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Topological Data Analysis – Lecture 2

Sjoerd Beentjes & Siddharth Setlur

AGQ Computing Course

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Recap: Filtered simplicial complexes



Main example. Finite subset of points $M = \{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n\} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$

Definition. Let (M, d) be a finite metric space. The **Vietoris-Rips filtration** is an “increasing family” of simplicial complexes $VR_\epsilon(M)$ indexed by the real numbers $\epsilon \geq 0$ defined as follows:

A subset $\{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_k\} \subset M$ forms a k -dimensional simplex in $VR_\epsilon(M)$ if and only if we have $d(x_i, x_j) \leq \epsilon$ for all i, j

Definition. Let M be a finite subset of a metric space (Z, d) . The **Cech filtration** of M with respect to Z is the “increasing family” of simplicial complexes $C_\epsilon(M)$ indexed by the real numbers $\epsilon \geq 0$

A subset $\{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_k\} \subset M$ forms a k -dimensional simplex in $C_\epsilon(M)$ if and only if there is $z \in Z$ with $d(z, x_i) \leq \epsilon$ for all i

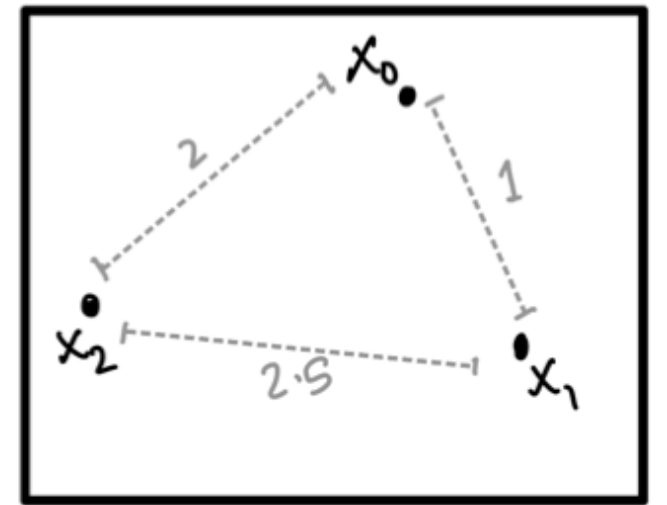
Recap: Filtered simplicial complexes



Main example. Finite subset of points $M = \{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n\} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$

$\text{VR}_\epsilon(M)$ is given by $d(x_i, x_j) \leq \epsilon$ for all i, j

$$\mathbf{VR}_\epsilon(M) = \begin{cases} \{x_0, x_1, x_2\} & 0 \leq \epsilon < 1 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1\} & 1 \leq \epsilon < 2 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1, x_0x_2\} & 2 \leq \epsilon < 2.5 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1, x_0x_2, x_1x_2, x_0x_1x_2\} & \epsilon \geq 2.5 \end{cases}$$



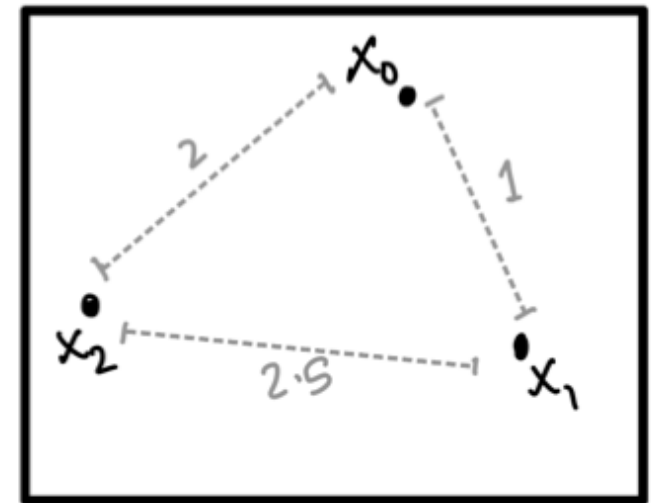
Recap: Filtered simplicial complexes



Main example. Finite subset of points $M = \{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n\} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$

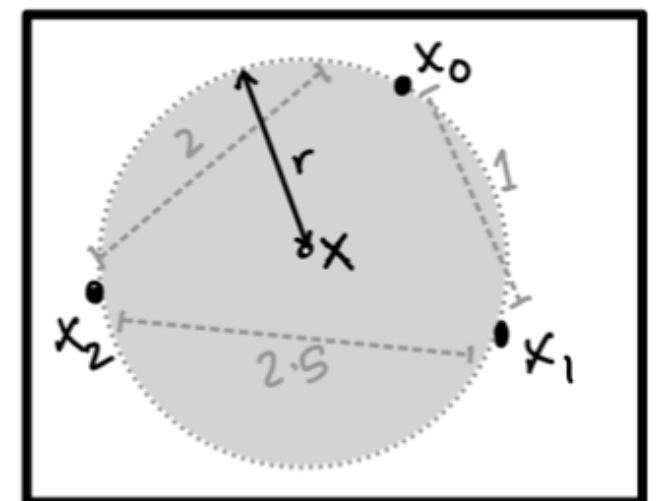
$\text{VR}_\epsilon(M)$ is given by $d(x_i, x_j) \leq \epsilon$ for all i, j

$$\mathbf{VR}_\epsilon(M) = \begin{cases} \{x_0, x_1, x_2\} & 0 \leq \epsilon < 1 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1\} & 1 \leq \epsilon < 2 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1, x_0x_2\} & 2 \leq \epsilon < 2.5 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1, x_0x_2, x_1x_2, x_0x_1x_2\} & \epsilon \geq 2.5 \end{cases}$$



$\mathbf{C}_\epsilon(M)$ is given by $z \in Z$ with $d(z, x_i) \leq \epsilon$ for all i

$$\mathbf{C}_\epsilon(M) = \begin{cases} \{x_0, x_1, x_2\} & 0 \leq \epsilon < 0.5 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1\} & 0.5 \leq \epsilon < 1 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1, x_0x_2\} & 1 \leq \epsilon < 1.25 \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1, x_0x_2, x_1x_2\} & 1.25 \leq \epsilon < r \\ \{x_0, x_1, x_2, x_0x_1, x_0x_2, x_1x_2, x_0x_1x_2\} & \epsilon \geq r \end{cases}$$

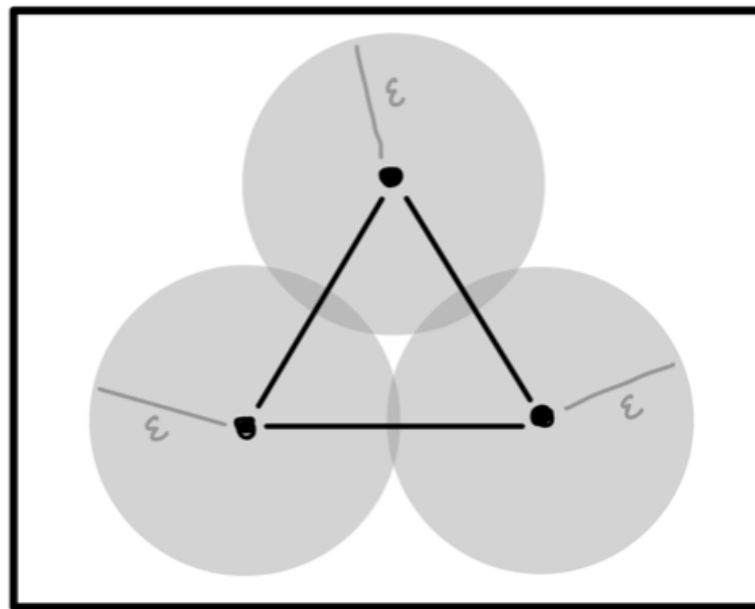


Recap: Filtered simplicial complexes



Conclusions. Finite subset of points $M = \{x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n\} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$

1. The Vietoris-Rips complex is a lot easier to compute — we only require the pairwise distances, which are given
2. However, the Čech complex is more faithful to the geometry of the union of balls which we sought to approximate, e.g.:



Exercise. Show $C_\epsilon(M) \subset VR_{2\epsilon}(M) \subset C_{2\epsilon}(M)$, regardless of Z

Statistical vectorisation

Definition. Given the barcode $B = \text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ of a tame PM with multiplicity $\mu: B \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ and an interval $[p, q]$, we call p the *birth*, q the *death*, and the length $q - p$ the *lifespan* of the bar, respectively.

Definition. The *persistence statistics vector* of $\mu: B \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ is

- The mean, standard deviation, median, interquartile range, full range, 10th, 25th, 75th, and 90th percentiles of the births p , the deaths q , the midpoints $(p+q)/2$, and lifespans $q - p$ for all intervals $[p, q]$ counted with multiplicity,
- Total number of bars (with multiplicity),

- The entropy $E_\mu = - \sum_{[p, q] \in B} \mu_{p, q} \left(\frac{q - p}{L_\mu} \right) \log \left(\frac{q - p}{L_\mu} \right) \in \mathbb{R}$

$$L_\mu = \sum_{[p, q] \in B} \mu_{p, q} \cdot (q - p)$$

Statistical vectorisation

Definition. Given the barcode $B = \text{Bar}(V_\bullet, a_\bullet)$ of a tame PM with multiplicity $\mu: B \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ and an interval $[p, q]$, we call p the *birth*, q the *death*, and the length $q - p$ the *lifespan* of the bar, respectively.

Definition. The *entropy summary function* of $\mu: B \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ is

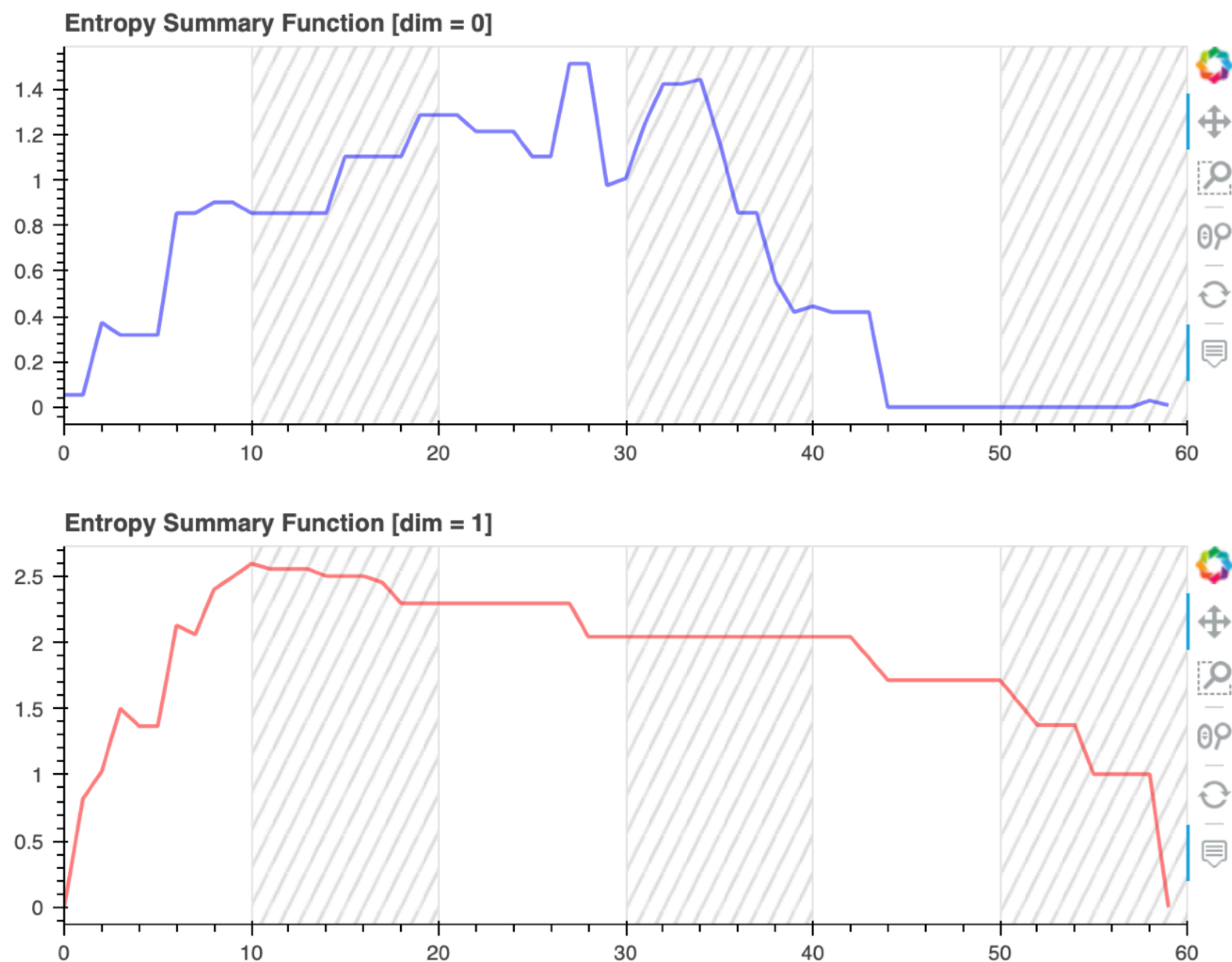
$$S_\mu(t) = - \sum_{[p, q] \in B} \mathbb{1}_{p \leq t \leq q} \cdot \mu_{p, q} \left(\frac{q - p}{L_\mu} \right) \log \left(\frac{q - p}{L_\mu} \right) \in \mathbb{R}$$

where $L_\mu = \sum_{[p, q] \in B} \mu_{p, q} \cdot (q - p)$ as before. Note that $S_\mu: \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$

In practice, we choose, e.g., 100 equally spaced values of the parameter t , and record the function as an object in $\mathbb{R}^{100}$.

Statistical vectorisation: Entropy

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